

Contraception - IUD Symptoms and Questions - Female (Adult)

Algorithm 1471 | Adult (18 years and older) | Gender at birth: Female

Definition

- IUD symptom assessment for a patient with a uterus and an IUD in place. Pregnancy, ectopic pregnancy, infection, perforation or displacement must be excluded before expected side effects are assumed.
- Adult patient.
- Female.

Initial assessment

1. [DURATION] When was the IUD fitted, and when were the threads last felt normally?
2. [OPEN_TEXT] Describe pain, bleeding, discharge, fever, faintness, vomiting, missed period, positive pregnancy test, and whether the device or threads feel different.
3. [YES_NO] Could the patient be pregnant, have they recently given birth, or was there unprotected sex after the threads changed or could not be felt?
4. [YES_NO] If the patient is under 18, can they speak privately now, do they feel safe with the accompanying adult and sexual partner, and is there any concern about coercion or assault?

Triage and redirect questions

1. Redirect → Pelvic Pain - Female

Is pelvic pain the main concern without an IUD-related symptom or question?

Female pelvic pain without an IUD concern belongs in the Pelvic Pain - Female pathway.

1. Disposition level 100

Is there collapse, fainting or marked dizziness, pale or clammy skin, heavy bleeding, severe or rapidly worsening lower abdominal/pelvic pain, sudden one-sided pain with vomiting, a rigid or very tender abdomen, confusion or severe illness? If pregnancy is possible, is there pain, bleeding, or shoulder-tip pain?

These features can indicate ruptured ectopic pregnancy, ovarian torsion, major bleeding, perforation, peritonitis, or sepsis. Pregnancy with an IUD has an increased relative risk of being ectopic.

1. Disposition level 70

Without emergency features, is pregnancy suspected, can the threads not be felt or do they feel different, can the device be felt, is there persistent pain, fever, abnormal or smelly discharge, very heavy bleeding, pain during sex, recent postpartum insertion, or is the patient under 18 or reporting coercion or an unsafe caregiver?

These findings require in-person pregnancy testing, pelvic assessment and possible ultrasound, infection testing, device-position check, emergency-contraception discussion, or safeguarding assessment.

1. Disposition level 15

Are these mild expected cramps or bleeding changes soon after fitting, with pregnancy excluded, threads unchanged, and none of the emergency, urgent, adolescent, postpartum, or safeguarding features above?

NHS.UK describes mild period-like pain and bleeding changes as common after fitting, but this branch requires all higher-risk features to be absent.

Advice

Emergency IUD complication precautions

- Call Qatar emergency services on 999 now. Keep the patient at rest and do not let them drive. Tell the call handler about the IUD and any possible pregnancy or recent birth. Call Qatar 999 now, follow the call-taker's ambulance and emergency-transport instructions, and do not self-drive. Do not delay emergency care.
- Call Back If: collapse or fainting; pain or bleeding worsens.

Urgent in-person IUD assessment

- Arrange urgent in-person gynecology, early-pregnancy, pediatric or safeguarding assessment as applicable; the exact non-emergency Qatar destination requires local approval. If threads cannot be felt or have changed, do not rely on the IUD for contraception until checked; a clinician must assess whether emergency contraception and pregnancy testing are needed.
- Call Back If: pain, faintness, fever, discharge, or bleeding worsens.

Monitoring expected IUD effects

- Mild cramps and bleeding changes can occur after fitting. A clinician or pharmacist should confirm any pain medicine is suitable, especially for a patient under 18, pregnant/postpartum, taking other medicines, or with kidney disease, ulcers, asthma triggered by anti-inflammatory medicines, or bleeding risk.
- Call Back If: pain becomes severe or persistent; fever, abnormal discharge, heavy bleeding, pregnancy concern, or changed threads develops.

First aid

- Call Qatar emergency services on 999 now. Keep the patient at rest and do not let them drive. Tell the call handler about the IUD and any possible pregnancy or recent birth. Call Qatar 999 now, follow the call-taker's ambulance and emergency-transport instructions, and do not self-drive. Do not delay emergency care.

References

- NHS.UK, "IUD (coil) - Side effects", <https://www.nhs.uk/contraception/methods-of-contraception/iud-coil/side-effects/>
- NICE NG126, "Ectopic pregnancy and miscarriage: symptoms, signs and initial assessment", <https://www.nice.org.uk/guidance/ng126/chapter/symptoms-and-signs-of-ectopic-pregnancy-and-initial-assessment>

Provenance

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